degree and a job, but she wanted her only son to be with her. And here I was, to take care of her, but unsure for how long. I took her to Trivandrum-based Dr Narayana Pai, the biggest name in cardiology in that part of the world then. I knew I had to find a job, but leaving my mother to work far away did not sound good. And then came the monthly groceries from AT Ganapathiya Pillai's shop in Chaalai Bazaar that was to solve my problem.

One of the items was wrapped in a newspaper which I was about to throw into the bin when a two-column advertisement on it caught my eye. Thumba Equatorial Rocket Launching Station (TERLS) in Trivandrum was inviting applications for the post of Technical Assistant (Design). The qualification: a degree in mechanical engineering. The candidate should have graduated with a first class. I fitted the bill, but had no idea what the fledgling TERLS was, and what was expected of the technical assistant. Then I saw the ad again: the last day for applying was the previous day. It was 3 September 1966.

I knew TERLS was a government set-up, and they would not entertain applications beyond the deadline, as bureaucratic strictures do not make allowances of flexibility even if it is for the better. Nevertheless, I decided to make an attempt. I took my cousin R Subbiah's Fiat and drove to the seaside TERLS, which was then but an old church and the bishop's house converted into a working space for India's space programme. The genesis, as I later learned, was in 1962 when Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru set up Indian National Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR) under Vikram Sarabhai to formulate India's space programme. It was to later grow into the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). Sarabhai had taken over from Homi J Bhabha as the head of Department of Atomic Energy. Incidentally, on 24 January 1966, the day Bhabha died in a plane crash over Mont Blanc, Indira Gandhi took over as the Prime Minister. Sarabhai enjoyed a fine rapport with Indira, which kept ISRO in good stead.

Sarabhai set up TERLS and made HGS Murthy its first director.

I walked up to the desk of P A Kurien, administration assistant with my application form. 'It's all over,' said Kurien, 'but you can try your luck with the director.' Murthy turned out to be a considerate person, and TERLS—